

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Data source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025) | 2023 global estimates

PREVALENCE

Hundreds of Millions Affected

LIFETIME RISK OF MAJOR DEPRESSION — WOMEN

1 in 3 women

will experience major depression in their lifetime

LIFETIME RISK OF MAJOR DEPRESSION — MEN

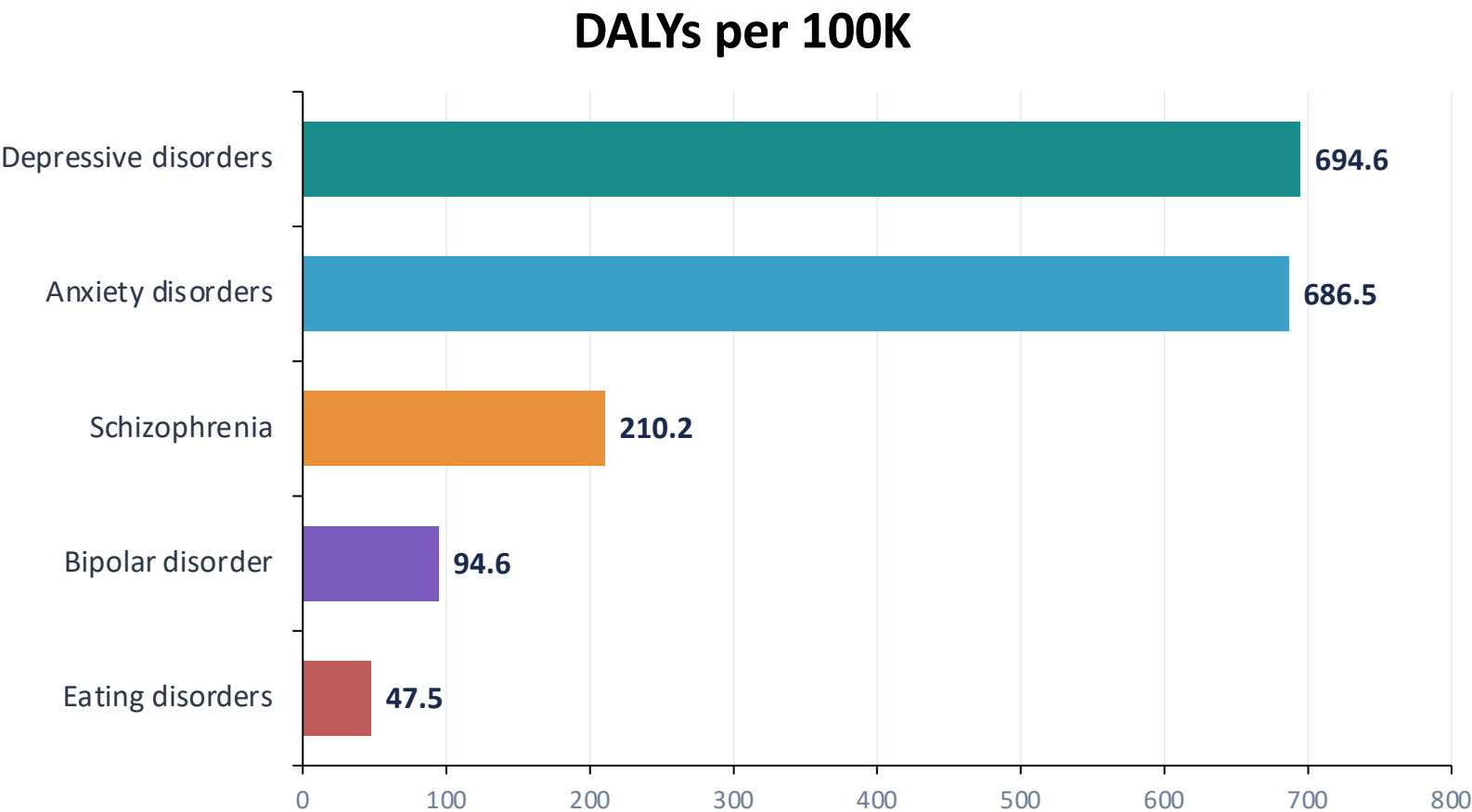
1 in 5 men

will experience major depression in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from common disorders like depression and anxiety to less common but severe conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder. Understanding the scale is the first step toward effective policy.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Global Mental Health DALYs

Disability-adjusted life years (DALYs) per 100,000 people, World, 2023



~80%

of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories comes from depression and anxiety alone.

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people — World, 2023

**Depressive
Disorders**



694.6

**Anxiety
Disorders**

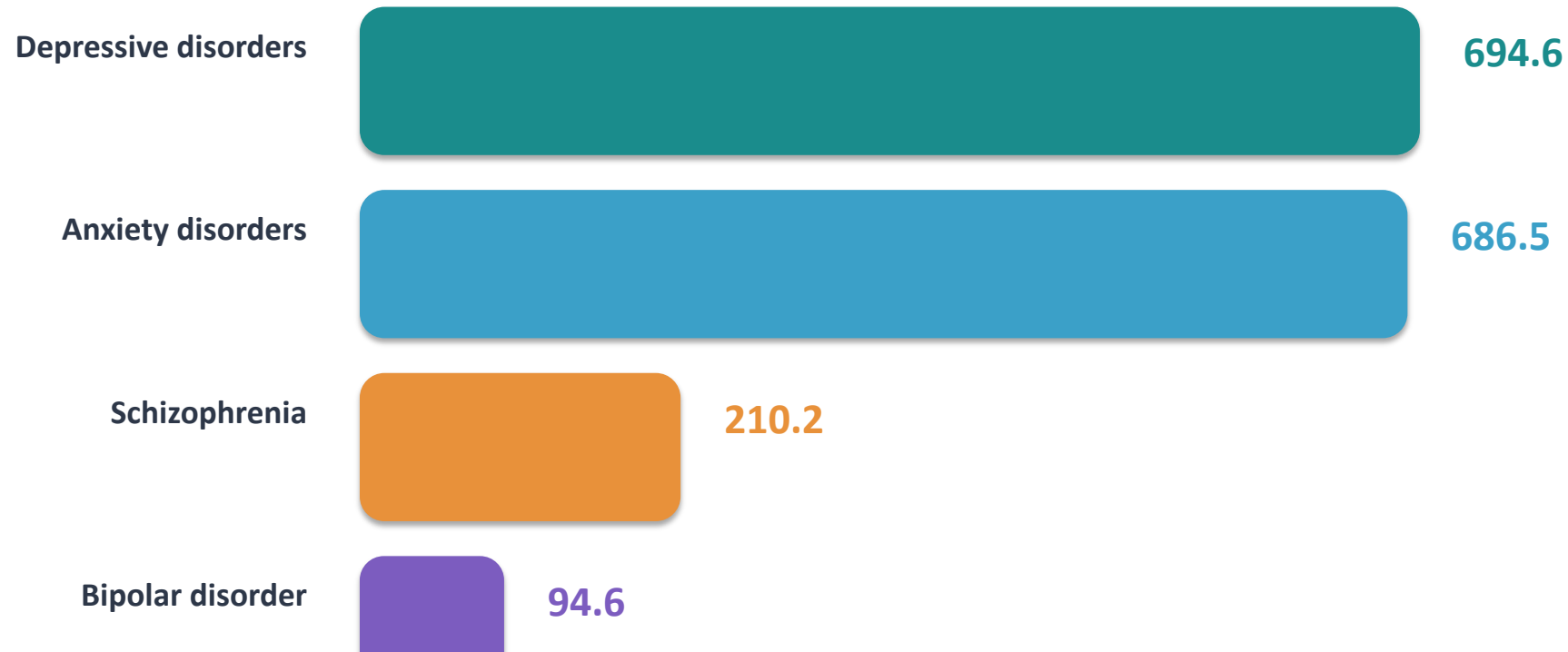


686.5

Difference: **8.1 DALYs per 100K** — just 1.2% separates them

Together, depression and anxiety account for the vast majority of mental health burden, dwarfing all other categories combined.

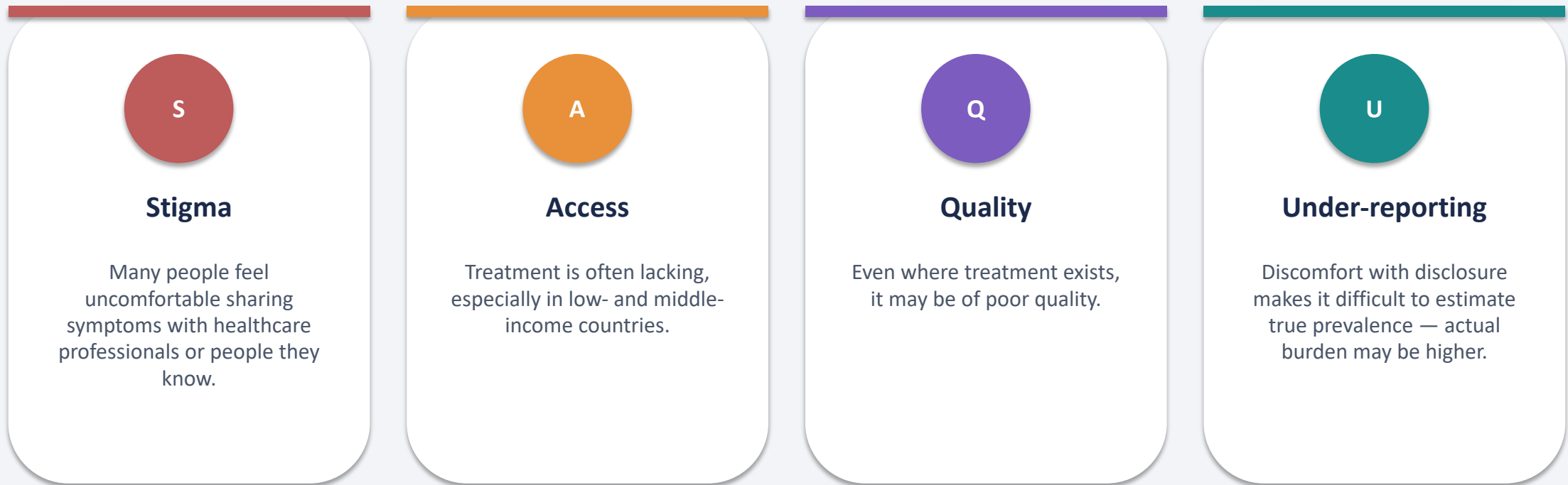
Schizophrenia and Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact



Key insight: While schizophrenia and bipolar affect fewer people, they cause profound disability for each individual. Schizophrenia alone contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100K — reflecting severe, persistent disability that demands specialized care.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced — yet significant barriers persist.



"Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, how many people are affected, and how they can be treated effectively and safely."

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression.



Taking Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare access and pharmaceutical availability are greater.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide — a culturally embedded coping mechanism.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across countries and income levels.

Policy interventions must account for cultural, economic, and healthcare system differences — a one-size-fits-all approach will not work.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

1

Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — each generating ~690 DALYs per 100,000 people.

2

Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence, demanding specialized care pathways.

3

Effective treatments exist, but access and quality remain inadequate — the treatment gap is a policy failure, not a knowledge gap.

4

Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.

5

Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.